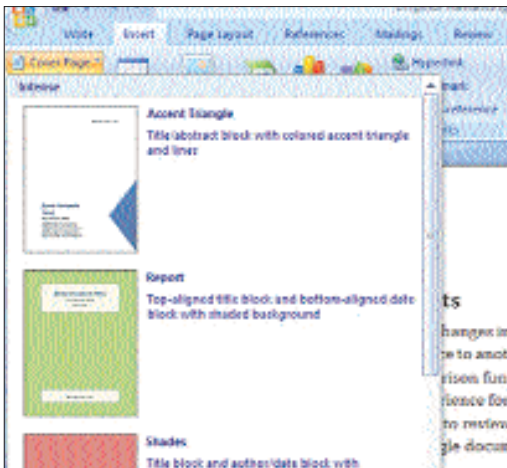
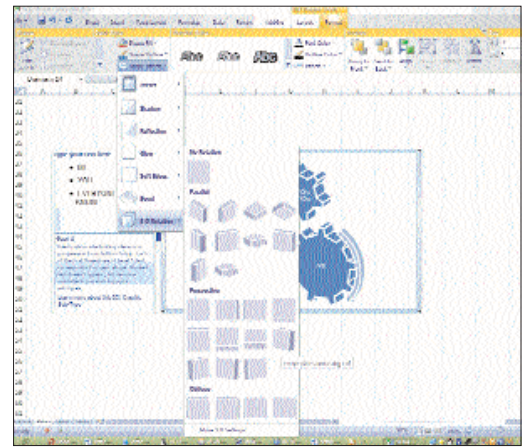




You pick and click from Galleries to format your document

On the whole, what we took away from the Office 12 Beta was that it offers a new chassis on what is essentially the same engine



Office 12 offers 3D effects and rotation for several elements. This is a diagram tool for creating Venn diagrams and such

storing data and brings with it flexibility, data robustness, and of course, file compression, thanks to the ZIP format.

Data recovery is also improved under such a scheme: say an embedded image gets corrupted while the file is transferred over wires—you would still be able to recover the remaining data. The modular approach also offers an organisation flexibility, since elements can be added or dropped according to requirements. Finally, XML is data-driven. A workplace can thus leverage this document structure to enable content gathering from disparate sources, create documents based on the varied content, put up the document for data mining, and also reuse content.

Apart from this overarching change in Office 2007, there are minor additions made to each element of the suite. Outlook, for example, adds a To-Do Bar, which lists pending tasks and adds a calendar view. Creating tasks from an e-mail is now a right-click away: a created task is automatically added to the To-Do Bar. Also present is an improved Calendar view, RSS feed integration, and a better search tool.

Most of the feature additions are meant for large businesses. The Microsoft Enterprise Content Management offering in Microsoft Office SharePoint Server 2007, for example, offers Web content management, record management and document management. It also includes search



and workflow features to leverage all the data. Outlook can now mail calendars as HTML files such that non-Exchange users can be kept in the loop. The new OneNote 12 applies OCR to collected data such as images, thus enhancing the ability to scan for and collate data. The new suite also brings in tighter integration—among the constituent programs (such as Outlook, OneNote and InfoPath) as also between the PC and connected devices, such as cell phones and PDAs.

Old Wine In A New Bottle?

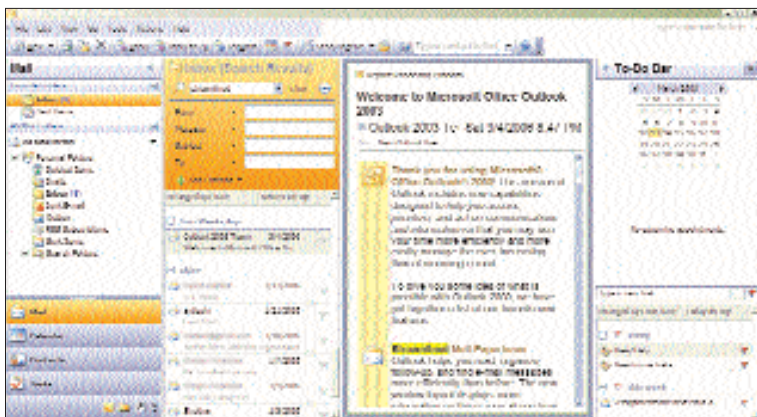
On the whole, what we took away from the Office 12 Beta was that it offers a new chassis on what is essentially the same engine. The new interface is very good, and will be a huge boon to those of us not very familiar with the inner plumbing of the current Office suite. To a power user, however, Office 12 offers little more than a prettier way to do things.

While on this point, the new interface leverages new hardware, particularly graphics accelerators. The interface worked almost flawlessly on an integrated nVidia platform, powered by a GeForce 6150 onboard chip. Almost, because it did display the occasional graphical glitch...

Notably, while Word, Excel and PowerPoint ran nice and stable, Outlook was a bit jittery and was prone to crashing.

But it's beta software; stability is bound to improve, system requirements apt to fall. As for feature additions, we don't think anything more will be added to the Office gene pool, and quite frankly, little needs to be. As it stands, Office 2003 is a very comprehensive package in terms of features. So would you be willing to invest the money and the relearning required to upgrade from the 2003 suite to the 2007 version? Should you even consider such an upgrade? We will answer these questions when we review the retail version of Microsoft Office 2007. For now, we can only report that the new interface is indeed an elegant solution, which ably exposes the expansive capabilities of the Office suite. Our congratulations to the Office team at Microsoft for delivering that. ■

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Outlook 12's interface adds a new To-Do bar, support for RSS subscriptions, and search